Hardware — atoms are expensive, evidence doesn’t have to be

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What changes: iteration cycles cost weeks and money, so you buy MORE evidence before building, not less. Juicero (M00 case) is your founding myth — $120M of hardware, €0 of demand testing. Never be the pedestal.

Your wallet-equivalents: deposits (€50 refundable counts — it’s real commitment), pre-orders at real price, paid design-partnerships with the first B2B users. Crowdfunding pledges count as validation WITH the caveat: campaign traffic you bought is not organic demand.

Your ladder translation: M04: landing page with PRE-ORDER button at the real intended price (click-to-preorder rate is your threshold, even if you don’t charge yet — but charging deposits beats everything). M05: a looks-like click dummy or 3D print that people from your segment try, a prop that collects signal. M06: a works-like build, where Wizard-of-Oz electronics behind the 3D print are a fine way to learn, and it becomes a prototype once somebody pays for it; McDonald’s chalk lines (M06) are your spirit animal. M08: sell deposits, hand-deliver the first units yourself. M09 pricing: BOM is your floor, value is your price; never price from cost. Deposits through the checkout at the real price. tado° (M09 case) is your pricing case: a box, a service and three ways to pay for them. M10 retention: use after purchase, counted from the device’s own data where it has any, and the second order or the accessory.

Your traps: tooling/certification before demand, “we need €50k before we can test anything” (you don’t — you need a render and 20 conversations), confusing maker-community applause with customers.

Kill criteria that bite: preorders on target-segment traffic stay below a line you set before the test · nobody accepts a paid deposit after the number of asks you set · BOM math can’t reach a viable margin even at scale assumptions you’d defend in a tribunal.